Ways We Defend the "Good White Self"

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Denial or minimization of oppression and white privilege

- Minimizing/denying difference, "color blindness"
- Spiritual bypass: using spiritual ideas and practices to sidestep the uncomfortable feelings around race
- Blaming the BIPOC - "she's too sensitive, too defensive. What I did wasn't that bad."
- Revert to our own subjugated identities (gender, class, disabled, etc.) as a way to not acknowledge white privilege

Enactment on the interpersonal level

- Withdrawing from interacting - emotionally, intellectually, socially and/or physically
- Focusing on our intent vs. the impact of what happened on person from targeted group
- Shifting the discussion to our own experience of oppression
- Using shame/guilt/distress as a buffer/show-stopper
- Not being willing to take risks, make mistakes. Not going outside our comfort zone. Staying quiet and letting others make mistakes.
- Hearing a person of color's experience of racism as an 'attack'
- Blaming the person who is raising race related issues for our feelings
- Believing our feelings are facts (if I feel attacked, that's what happened)
- Asserting the 'right' to be seen as an individual rather than as a member of our racial group membership
- Assuming my experience is "right" - feeling "enlightened" and self-righteous about the situation.

Enactment on the intrapersonal level

- Assuming/insisting that race is not at play in any given interaction
- Assuming our perspective is 'right' - if it doesn't make sense to us that means it doesn't make sense. Assuming our sense of timing is right.
- Refusal to explore/accept/acknowledge our racial/racist conditioning
- 'Wanting' to be anti-racist without giving up any privileges
- Equating discomfort/distress with lack of safety
- "I'm not like other white people." Judging and separating oneself from other white people.
- Intellectualization - focusing on the intellectual understanding of the situation to minimize the anxiety-provoking/difficult emotions you're feeling. Separating the emotions from the ideas.
- Rationalization - convincing oneself that the situation is not as bad as it seems, that no wrong has been done and all is ok
- Social comparisons - convincing oneself that what you did was not as bad as it could have been or that you managed the difficult situation better than someone else would have. Assuming you are more skillful.
- Using distraction - thinking of anything else or purposefully finding things to do, to distract oneself from the mistake or mess you made.
- Dissociation – "zoning out" to escape difficult feelings
- Confusion/delusion - staying in a state of confusion, bewilderment, feeling muddled.
- Using sadness and doubt as reasons for giving up
- Misusing the concept that it's OK to make mistakes to shirk responsibility for the impact of what was said/done/or not done.

Making use of Black, Indigenous and People of Color

- Wanting redemption/approval/acceptance from people of color
- Denigrating BIPOC in order to feel better about ourselves
- Assuming all BIPOC will naturally want to be in relationship with us: assuming trust, tokenism (“my black friend”)